

These are the rules for a document to conform to the XML standard. However, depending on the nature or use of the XML document, further restrictions may apply. For example, in case of RSS feeds, the tag names, and the way they are supposed to be nested is clearly defined.

XHTML is another example of an XML-compliant format with extra requirements. XHTML is not a new language; it is merely an update to HTML, to make it compliant with the XML standard. HTML has some syntactical elements that do not abide by the XML standard. For all future purposes, HTML will follow the XML standard.

2.4 XML in AJAX

XML is a very powerful way of implementing AJAX. However, this is not essential. XML is used in AJAX primarily to retrieve data from the server, and unlike the examples shown, the XML code is usually generated on the fly using server-side scripts along with database access. RSS feeds provided by major sites are basically server-side scripts, which compile a list of items from the requested list, and puts them in an XML format that is compliant with RSS.

Server-side scripting is out of the scope of this book. However, you shouldn't feel like you have accomplished nothing. You can still work with static XML files you create, or you can use the XML feeds provided by a variety of applications found on the web.

2.4.1 Disadvantages of using XML

One of the biggest disadvantages of XML is often the fact that it has a lot of overhead. This means that the actual data content of an XML file is quite low, as a lot of space is wasted in tags. As a result, this is not a very efficient medium for transporting data.

Consider the following example:

```
<addressbook>
  <contact>
    <name>
      Tag Jones
    </name>
```